

# Moon Mission Makeover: Astronauts Will Test Space Docking, Not Walk on the Moon!

From: BBC News Mined: 2026-06-09 3 min read

Imagine training for the biggest race of your life, but then the finish line gets moved to a completely different track! That's kind of what just happened to four **astronauts**. NASA picked the crew for Artemis III, a **mission** that was supposed to put the first people on the Moon since 1972. But now, they won't even go near it. Instead, they'll stay in low Earth **orbit**, about the same height as the International Space Station, and practice connecting their spaceship to Moon **landers**. Commander Randy Bresnik will lead the team. Italian astronaut Luca Parmitano, who has spent over 300 days in space, will be the pilot. Americans Andre Douglas and Frank Rubio are the **mission** specialists, and Bob Heintz is the backup he can fill any role if needed. So why the big change? The giant Starship rocket from SpaceX, meant to carry **astronauts** to the Moon's surface, isn't ready. It's so heavy it needs to **refuel** in space, a tricky move never tested before. Plus, Blue Origin's New Glenn rocket blew up during a test last month, damaging the launch pad badly. That delays other Moon **landers**. NASA still hopes Artemis III will fly in 2027 as a test, with a real landing in 2028. But many experts think that timeline is super **ambitious** like trying to finish a year's worth of homework in one night!

## Word Treasure

**astronauts** -- People trained to travel and work in space.

**mission** -- A very important job or goal, often for a group of explorers.

**orbit** -- The curved path a spacecraft follows around a planet or moon.

**landers** -- Vehicles designed to softly touch down on the surface of the moon or a planet.

**refuel** -- To fill up a spaceship with more fuel while it is already in space.

**ambitious** -- A plan that is very big, difficult, and requires a lot of effort to achieve.

## Background you need

The last time people walked on the Moon was in 1972 during the Apollo 17 mission. Since then, only robots have visited the lunar surface.

Astronauts often practice connecting to other spacecraft in low Earth orbit, near the International Space Station (a giant floating laboratory).

SpaceX (Elon Musk's rocket company) and Blue Origin (Jeff Bezos's space company) are both building Moon landers, but the technology is very new and has hit delays.

## Break it down

**WHO:** The Artemis III crew -- commander Randy Bresnik, pilot Luca Parmitano, mission specialists Andre Douglas and Frank Rubio, and backup Bob Heintz.

**WHAT:** Their mission changed from landing on the Moon to practicing docking with Moon landers in low Earth orbit.

**WHERE:** In low Earth orbit, about the same height as the International Space Station.

**WHY:** The Starship rocket isn't ready and must test refueling in space; a Blue Origin rocket explosion also delayed other landers.

## Why it matters

It shows that even big plans can change, and scientists must be patient and solve problems step by step -- just like when you practice before a big game or test.

## Test what you remember

**1. What was the original goal of the Artemis III mission?**

- ☐ (A) Test space docking in Earth orbit
- ☐ (B) Put the first people on the Moon since 1972
- ☐ (C) Launch a telescope to study stars
- ☐ (D) Send robots to Mars

**2. Who will lead the Artemis III crew as commander?**

- ☐ (A) Luca Parmitano
- ☐ (B) Andre Douglas
- ☐ (C) Randy Bresnik
- ☐ (D) Frank Rubio

**3. Why was the mission changed to practice docking instead of landing on the Moon?**

- ☐ (A) The astronauts got sick
- ☐ (B) The Moon is too cold for a landing
- ☐ (C) The giant Starship rocket isn't ready
- ☐ (D) NASA lost government funding

**4. What tricky move has never been tested before with the Starship rocket?**

- ☐ (A) Launching from the Moon
- ☐ (B) Refueling in space
- ☐ (C) Landing on Mars
- ☐ (D) Carrying ten astronauts at once

**5. Which company's rocket blew up during a test, delaying other Moon landers?**

- ☐ (A) SpaceX
- ☐ (B) Blue Origin
- ☐ (C) NASA
- ☐ (D) Boeing

**6. When does NASA still hope to have a real Moon landing?**

- ☐ (A) 2025
- ☐ (B) 2026
- ☐ (C) 2027
- ☐ (D) 2028

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: D

1. **Excited about safety:** Some people feel excited that astronauts will test new docking skills, which will make future Moon landings safer for everyone.
2. **Disappointed by delays:** Others are disappointed because they hoped to see new Moon walks soon, and delays might mean younger astronauts get the chance instead.
3. **Smart adjustment:** Experts see this as a wise change to avoid dangerous failures, even if it means waiting longer for a real landing.

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**